What ultimately shaped our understanding of design thinking was the experience of applying it inside the moving and sometimes ambiguous context of a real client project. Working with ShopSight meant we could not treat design thinking as a neatly defined sequence; instead, we had to adapt it constantly as new constraints, priorities, and questions emerged. Each week, our direction shifted slightly based on what the client emphasized. One week, the urgency was customer engagement, the next it was communicating sustainability without overwhelming users, and later it was authentically recognizing creators. Navigating these evolving priorities forced us to use design thinking as a flexible approach for aligning multiple perspectives. Without a client, we might have learned the stages, but we would not have experienced how design thinking actually functions as a negotiation between user needs, business realities, and feasibility. The project introduced stakes, accountability, and the need to translate insights into something a partner could genuinely adopt.

Our final meeting with Nick felt less like a presentation and more like a working session with someone who saw real potential in what we built. He did not just say he liked our solutions. He connected each one to real gaps he sees as ShopSight works with brands that often make creative decisions without reliable Gen Z insight. When we walked him through Trend Polls, he tied it to the forecasting blind spots he had raised earlier. He explained that brands are constantly forced to design months in advance without meaningful real-time signals and described our polling model as exactly the kind of upstream insight brands have been missing. With Creator Spotlight, he went a step further. He talked about the challenge of balancing authenticity with scale and how elevating everyday creators who spark trends early could differentiate ShopSight. Transparency Cards sparked the longest and most detailed feedback. Nick appreciated that the feature finally makes sustainability feel concrete instead of performative and emphasized how rare it is for brands to offer clarity that Gen Z genuinely trusts. His one concern was thoughtful. Some brands might selectively reveal flattering sustainability data while hiding the rest. He saw this not as a flaw but as a design challenge that would make the feature stronger. By the end of the meeting, it was clear he viewed our recommendations as feasible and aligned with the direction he envisions for ShopSight.

Reflecting on our final set of solutions, we feel genuinely proud of their clarity and grounding in real insight. Trend Polls captured Gen Z frustration about brands never asking for input, Creator Spotlight addressed the gap in recognizing early cultural influence, and Transparency Cards responded directly to skepticism around sustainability claims. If we were to enhance the solutions further, we would focus on a stronger verification framework for Transparency Cards, exploring category-specific versions of Trend Polls, and refining creator discovery so smaller voices are surfaced more reliably.

The most difficult obstacle we faced was making sense of the wide range of needs and emotions that emerged throughout the project. Every conversation surfaced a different priority, and for weeks, it felt like we were trying to design for sustainability frustrations, trust issues, discovery challenges, creator visibility, and transparency all at once. The sheer spread of insights made it hard to find a clear center of gravity. We finally broke through when we shifted away from trying to satisfy every need and instead looked for the emotional patterns that cut across them. Once we mapped the recurring themes of feeling unheard by brands, feeling skeptical of sustainability claims, and feeling overlooked as creators, the path forward became clear, and the project moved with much more momentum.

One of the most valuable lessons we learned about client management was the importance of bringing the client into our thinking early rather than waiting for polished ideas. Some of the most productive moments came from sharing half-formed sketches or questions we were genuinely stuck on, because it gave Nick room to guide our direction. We also realized how essential focused and high-leverage questions are. Whenever we asked broad prompts, the conversation stayed surface level, but when we asked questions such as ‘What would prevent this from working’ or ‘Where could this break down for brands’, the discussion became much richer. Listening for what the client emphasizes repeatedly, including credibility, authenticity, and feasibility, helped us prioritize effectively. We learned that effective client management is less about presenting perfect work and more about building a rhythm where the client feels included and understood.

Building on that, our regular meetings with Nick became an important part of maintaining that rhythm. Each check-in kept us aligned with what ShopSight actually needed and ensured we were not drifting into solutions that looked good on paper but would fall apart in practice. If anything, we would prepare more intentionally by sending short pre-reads or early sketches beforehand and sharing rough ideas sooner. The meetings were consistently valuable, and with slightly more structure from us, they could have been even more impactful.

Looking back on the overall project, the main thing we would do differently is shape our synthesis earlier. We spent too long gathering insights before narrowing to the patterns that mattered most. Prototyping rough concepts sooner would also have accelerated clarity and surfaced feasibility questions. Establishing clearer internal milestones would have reduced early ambiguity and created a smoother pattern.

To enhance our learning around the design thinking process itself, we would focus on more deliberate transitions between stages. Although we followed the structure outlined in the course, we often moved between phases without articulating the assumptions guiding us. Treating each stage as a checkpoint, from What Is to What If to What Wows to What Works, would have clarified what exactly we were learning and how it shaped the next step. Prototyping earlier and documenting our reasoning more explicitly would have made the process even more reflective.

The most valuable feedback Nick shared centered on Transparency Cards and the risk that brands might selectively reveal sustainability data. This shifted how we think about responsible design. It reminded us that solving a user problem is only part of the work. The other part is anticipating behaviors, incentives, and unintended consequences. This perspective pushed us to think more rigorously about guardrails, credibility, and long-term feasibility. Going forward, we plan to incorporate this mindset by asking early in the process how a feature might be misused and what protections are needed to maintain trust. Nick’s emphasis on clarity, authenticity, and operational realism shaped the most lasting lesson of the project. Great design is not only about creating something meaningful. It also requires ensuring it holds up against how the real world will actually use it.